



the mill in a logging town, for example, their economy will grind to a halt. The battle system has been improved and now any weapon can be wielded in either hand, including gloves used for magic. That means it will be up to you if you wish to use a sword and shield, a sword with an axe, or any other combination you like. If you choose to wield magical gloves in both hands your spells will become more powerful. After exploring the town we are shown a cave system, which should no longer feel pointless and derivative as most of them have now been designed by hand rather than randomly generated as they were in Oblivion. Upon exiting the cave we are met with what are sure to be the stars of Skyrim – dragons. They are a site to behold, with AI that fully controls their actions. When they swoop at you or crash to the ground it isn't because they were scripted to do so which means every epic battle will be unique as you run for cover and protection or try to mount the dragon's head for a brutal attack. If the entire 300+ hour game is as impressive as this all-too-brief 30 minutes Bethesda may have created one of the best role-playing games of all-time.

Several other games rounded out the highlights of the show. Mass Effect 3 (360, PS3, PC) has increased in scale, with larger battlefields and a story that now brings the battle with the Reapers to earth. Interesting changes include the ability to use mechanized armor and branching upgrades for your character's special abilities. Bioshock: Infinite (360, PS3, PC) was also gaining quite a bit of attention. Having the city floating in the sky has opened an entirely new world of gameplay for the developers, with areas connected by rail in the sky that you can connect to and move

at a blistering pace. Your new sidekick also provides the unique ability to open rifts and connect you to other worlds – at E3 one of those rifts took you to 1983 and the opening of Star Wars: Return of the Jedi. Moments like these are sure to keep things interesting.

Rounding out the top games of the show are Battlefield 3 and Tomb Raider. For fans of the series, the newest installment of Battlefield is sure to impress. My hands-on multiplayer demo of the game suggests better graphics and tighter gameplay mechanics than ever before. The newest in the Tomb Raider franchise takes the series down a darker path by telling the origin story of Lara Croft. Role-playing elements flesh out the game and help bring new life to the series.

Surprise of the Show

The biggest surprise of the show for me comes from Nexon. I don't normally expect much from free to play games but Vindictus and Dragon Nest may have finally won me over. Vindictus is a third-person fighting game with role-playing elements. It was fun, fast paced, and played well. Dragon Nest is a more of a massively multiplayer action RPG. I was able to enjoy several rounds of player versus player combat and found it hard to stop smiling the entire time. There is just something inherently fun about playing as a cute sorceress and beating up a menacing warrior. When the game launches there will be four classes to choose from but you can expect more to be added later. Neither game is available worldwide yet but they are working to introduce them as quickly as possible. Clearly the free to play delivery system is maturing and thanks to Nexon, has finally reached a point where even those who consider themselves hardcore gamers must take a serious look.

Best New Hardware

While many members of the media went in to the show looking forward to Nintendo's Wii replacement, it was Sony's

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